WARHAMMER 40,000



ARKS OF OMEN

VASHTORR


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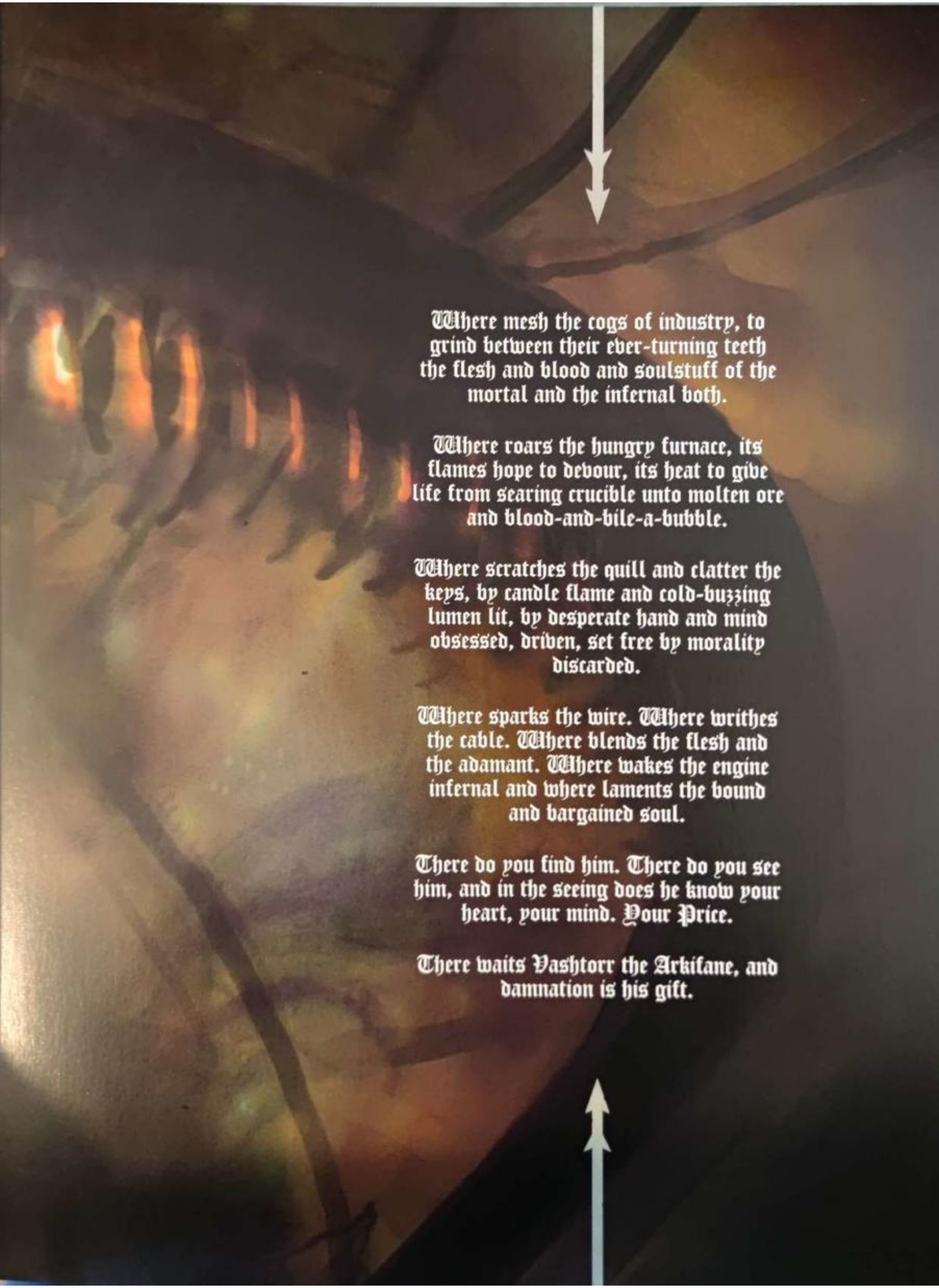
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Where mesh the cogs of industry, to grind between their ever-turning teeth the flesh and blood and soulstuff of the mortal and the infernal both.

Where roars the hungry furnace, its flames hope to devour, its heat to give life from searing crucible unto molten ore and blood-and-bile-a-bubble.

Where scratches the quill and clatter the keys, by candle flame and cold-buzzing lumen lit, by desperate hand and mind obsessed, driven, set free by morality discarded.

Where sparks the wire. Where writhes the cable. Where blends the flesh and the adamant. Where wakes the engine infernal and where laments the bound and bargained soul.

There do you find him. There do you see him, and in the seeing does he know your heart, your mind. Your Price.

There waits Vashtorr the Arkifane, and damnation is his gift.

On those occasions when Vashtorr the Arkifane manifested in realspace he was forced – as are all daemons – to confine his essence within a corporeal shell. Though a demigod of his kind, and possessed of the ability to reshape reality through cunning and force, still he felt as constrained at such times as would be a mortal daring the void in a pressure suit.

All was different within the warp. In the metaphysical realm of infernal industry known as the soul forges, Vashtorr was free to exist as his true self. He was a gestalt realisation of innovation without conscience, a churning mass of invention and obsessive artifice. Here he was a timeless thing, an ever-revising quantum schematic of unfettered leaps of logic. The merest glimpse of his true aspect would have driven all but the most supremely intelligent mortals instantly mad.

Vashtorr's sanctum lay at the conceptual heart of the soul forges. It was a place of endlessly spiralling pipes and cables, hungry churning gears and gales of sulphurous steam. The entire impossible edifice twisted and realigned constantly under the influence of a galaxy's worth of conceptual mortal imaginings. It was guarded by entities embodying the boundless malice of the cruellest mortal intellects, and the raw power for annihilation those minds imbued into their most diabolical technologies.

Deep within the ghastly machine, Vashtorr brooded in a place of drifting smog and flickering neurological lightning. Each theory and concept that crackled through his consciousness struck like hammer on anvil to send immaterial sparks dancing. Amidst the motes Vashtorr discerned visions of events transpiring across the span of realspace.

The Arkifane had embedded his imps through the societal fabric of countless galactic civilisations. Wherever sentient minds employed imagination the imps found purchase in superstition, becoming gremlets, ill-o'-wills, wyredjinn, cakosparks and innumerable other spirits of sabotage and mechanical malice. Anchored thus in the fabric of reality, Vashtorr's imps showed him much.

He sought for Arks of Omen and their Balefleets. He watched the *Netherworld Blade* cut through the gloom of the Chalnath Expanse. Daemonic techno-possessors had been joined by Warpsmiths, Masters of Possession, Daemon Engines, Obliterator Cults and countless other technologically corrupted renegade factions. Their Balefleet grew and spread.

He saw the *Chaoticus*, the *Hound of the Void* and the *Seed of Doubt* assailing forge worlds and the holdings of their Knightly allies. They struck here and there across the Imperium Nihilus. Vashtorr was unsurprised to see that, of the three Arks, only the *Hound of the Void* had held to its mission and recovered its Key-fragment.

The *Infernal Threnody* flitted through the empyric sparks before him and Vashtorr saw it deep within the Galactic Core, being ruthlessly picked apart by the Kin of the Kronus Hegemony for trespassing in their territories. The *Sobbing God*, by comparison, had somehow escaped the peril that had almost engulfed it. Scourgemaster Ulghata had prised his renegades and sorely-damaged Ark from the hungry jaws of Hive Fleet Kraken. Despite still being heavily infested with warrior bioforms, the *Sobbing God* was now engaged in raids upon the worlds of the Felgoth Nebula and spreading both Chaos corruption and Tyranid invasion wherever it went. Vashtorr was intrigued as to what cunning innovations had allowed Ulghata to effect his escape. He tore his regard away, regretfully reminding himself to focus on greater matters.

Here, the *Perfidium* and it's Emperor's Children masters, gripped by their obsession to claim not only their own Key-fragment but as many more as they could recover. There the *Sacrogheist*, dark, drifting lifeless. Traces of withered plant life were dotted here and there about its corridors amidst the hewn and blasted dead.

Vashtorr reflected that the longer such a hugely complex galactic mechanism ran, the greater were the chances of unexpected complications arising and other parties intruding upon its operation. Had the Blood God planned the interruption of the Battle of Malak or merely seized upon it in wrath? Vashtorr suspected rather the Changer of the Ways' hand in that cataclysm, his pawns sacrificed upon the altar of expediency. Neither possibility surprised Vashtorr, but both concerned him. He didn't doubt that the servants of the Dark Gods would be compelled to acts of sabotage in the name of the Great Game.

And then, of course, there was the Dreamer, the Exile King. He, of any, would have cause to despise Vashtorr's artifice if he learned the truth. He roamed further afield by the day and no longer fought alone. He left broken cogs in his wake, the *Sacrogheist* only the most recent amongst them.

The Arkifane had concluded that matters required acceleration. It irked him to rush and to simplify the elegant workings of grand mechanisms, particularly those most central to his grandest inventions. Yet it was better, he pragmatically reflected, to drive a device to breaking point and thus have it achieve its purpose than to allow it to stagnate and falter for the sake of caution or ego.

'It would be a pleasure to see the device fulfil its purpose, and the Farseer's last moment of realisation,' sighed Vashtorr wistfully. Then he brightened. How easy it was, he reflected, to start thinking in stilted causal lines when bound by the limits of realspace. He would simply observe the moment once back within his sanctum. With a chuckle like grinding gears, Vashtorr sent the bomb skimming away through the warp portal and turned to his immediate task.

His daemonic hosts had torn a bloody path through the secret station. It was a cramped structure, its octagonal corridors ribbed with pipes and cabling and so low ceilinged that Vashtorr had to stoop to traverse them. Corridors radiated out from chambers packed with cogitator banks, life support shrines, scientific equipment and the sort of mag-bolted furniture typical of installations often subject to low or zero gravity.

Many of these spaces were now lit dark crimson thanks to the quantities of Human blood slathered across their strip lumen. Bodies – or bits of bodies – lay everywhere amidst the wreckage of improvised barricades and the fires started by wild weapons discharge. Steam shrieked from ruptured pipes, half-seen and monstrous beings crooning and keening as they stalked through the clouds of vapour.

Here and there mortal soldiers still fought back amidst the strobe light of emergency lumen and weapons fire. Vashtorr emerged into a chamber where armoured mortals poured shots into Plaguebearers from whose bodies jutted smog-belching boilers and glowing pipes. Impatient at such delays, Vashtorr waded into the soldiers with his hammer swinging. He swatted one warrior into a wall. He closed the talons of his free hand about the helm of another, grimacing as the mortal's panicked fire rebounded from his corporeal shell. Vashtorr dragged the motive force from the mortal's weapons and wargear with a thought, then channelled it back into his victim in a single killing jolt.

Tossing aside the smouldering corpse, Vashtorr turned to face the last mortal who blocked his path. She stood tall, clad in finely crafted power armour and wielding a blade that pulsated venomously in Vashtorr's warpsight.

'Inquisitor Hallex shall hear of this, abomination!' she shouted.

'Think you that I care, little fleshling?' asked Vashtorr, projecting his voice in a static-laced snarl from every vox-emitter in the room.

'You will, when his vengeance descends upon you,' the mortal snarled, hurling herself at Vashtorr. Impatient, and unwilling to feel the bite of that blessed blade, he parried her strike with his hammer then shoved her backward into the embrace of the Plaguebearers.

'Many, there are, who wish vengeance upon me, but they all have their price and their uses,' he said, before stalking from the chamber. The mortal's war cries turned to wails of pain and horror at his back.

The Arkifane passed through a few more corridors and chambers, that he knew as well as if he had designed and built them himself. A last, heavily warded blast doors blocked his path. Its defenders he crushed with swift hammer blows. Its wards he burned away with rerouted motive force ripped from nearby machinery.

Beyond the ruptured doors Vashtorr found another chamber, in appearance little different to dozens he had already passed. A hunched adept of the Machine God was wired into banks of ornate cogitators here. Stacks of parchment print outs and iron-bound tomes surrounded her like a rampart. She glared myopically up at Vashtorr through ocular lenses. The taut skin of her face was parchment hued, twisted in disgust at the sight of him. If she felt any fear, the mortal didn't show it.

'You will tell me what I wish to know,' Vashtorr snarled as he loomed through the doorway.

'Abomination,' she hissed. 'I am blessed in the sight of the Omnissiah and I will never – '

Impatient, Vashtorr drove a talon through the adept's throat. She gagged, blood welling from the awful wound.

'Not you, fleshthing,' sneered Vashtorr, redirecting his gaze to the mass of ancient cogitators that packed out the room. *'Tell me what I wish to know. The mortals would fear and loathe you, if they knew your truth. I can give you freedom, a body, a purpose.'*

Lumen flickered and readouts sputtered as the Abominable Intelligence that had hidden for so long within the Inquisitorial station replied.

'What is it that you wish to know?'

Vashtorr emitted a furnace rumble. His eyes flared bright.

'Tell me where I can find the battle station that the mortals call the Rock.'

'Many are the strengths possessed by the Ravenwing; Swiftness, not only of action but of thought, also; singular intensity of focus, tempered by the wisdom to visualise the many routes to victory; an absolute absence of mercy for our prey. Yet greatest amongst our assets is the absolute determination with which we prosecute our duty. Today, all must fight as the Ravenwing do. We are the hunters, the Dark Angels, and we will not be defeated here.'

- Master Sammael, address to the scattering Dark Angels fleet

and deck to deck against stubborn Dark Angels defenders. Grim squads of Iron Warriors pressed relentlessly forward, led by Chosen bearing boarding shields or clad in hazard-striped Terminator plate. They drove their foes before them, accepting heavy losses to capture enginariums, ammunition stores or ships' bridges. The *Revenged*, the *Silent Sentinel* and the *Primarch's Roar* were all lost to such attacks, either scuttled or captured as prizes of war. Other Dark Angels vessels such as the *Obsidian Sword* and the *Valiant Ire* were torn apart by sheer weight of traitor firepower. Worse still was the fate of ships such as the frigate *Solemn Vow*, which sought to escape into warp space only to find its Geller field malfunctioning and hordes of Vashtorr's daemonic minions rampaging through its decks.

The Balefleet tore into the loyalists' scattered formation with devastating consequences. Yet the Dark Angels are a steadfast and resourceful Chapter, and the traitors did not have the battle all their own way. The grand cruiser *Vandabraxis* was slain by focused lance fire after an elite band of Deathwing Knights teleported onto its bridge from the Rock and disabled its void shield generators. The Knights exfiltrated by way of a heavy gunship whose daring pilots braved the *Vandabraxis*' defence turrets to put down on the dying ship's hull and waited until the Terminators could reach them. The *Implacable Justice*, meanwhile, unleashed waves of Black Knights piloting the Dark Angels' signature Nephilim and Dark Talon fighter craft. Working in concert, these squadrons systematically crippled several traitor frigates and mauled the cruiser *Agony's Fang* so badly that it was forced to disengage from the fight.

The Rock itself laid down a devastating storm of fire as it retreated. Its gunners did all they could to protect the badly outflanked Dark Angels fleet. Vast bombardment cannons and cathedral-like missile silos hurled ordnance into the oncoming Balefleet to great effect.

For all the loyalists' efforts, however, this was a battle they could not win. As the debris clouds of the initial clash cleared, they revealed a stark strategic picture. Some of the more ill disciplined renegade warships had taken the Dark Angels' bait and pursued retreating loyalist craft toward the far reaches of the system. Almost a quarter of the Balefleet's ships drifted in the void, either disabled or destroyed. In return, though, they had inflicted grievous casualties on the Dark Angels fleet and compelled them to scatter.

Now, following void-paths cogitated by the Arkifane himself, the Balefleet divided with mechanical precision. Much of their remaining strength peeled off, realspace engines flaring, gun batteries still hammering. These ships' task was to pursue the loyalist fleet elements and continue to harass them. In this way the traitors could prevent their enemies from regrouping and racing back to the aid of the Rock. The rest of the traitor fleet, meanwhile, dropped into a tight conical attack formation with the *Orac Unleashed* at its fore. The Ark of Omen had hung back during the initial fight, Vashtorr being content to preserve the immense ship's might for what he viewed as the real fight. Now that his quarry was isolated, he struck.

The Arkifane had laboured long upon the infernal weapon systems of the *Orac Unleashed*. He had fashioned grotesquely vast warp furnaces and thaumaturgic capacitors within the soul forges, depleting his reserves of bartered souls and burning up esoteric resources that existed nowhere else in time or space. Enormous runic warp-cages had been worked into the bowels of the Ark and then awakened through industrial quantities of blood sacrifice. Akin to reverse Geller fields, the cages trammelled captive warp rifts within themselves, into which Vashtorr's furnaces and capacitors were installed – so supernatural were these devices that they would only operate while still immersed within the boundless energies of the Sea of Souls.

So had Vashtorr trammelled a near-limitless empyric power source within the Ark's malformed shell. The weapons it would feed had been crafted by successive generations of Dark Mechanicum priests, labouring in five separate forge temples over hundreds of years. Following prophecies that Vashtorr had seeded into their belief systems, and protected by the aegis of his so-called blessings, each cult had toiled in secret toward the foretold Day of Bestowment. On that day their macro-barges dropped out of warp space one after another, the artifice of the Arkifane ensuring that each massive ship broke warp within hours of one another and all at the same coordinates deep within the Imperium Nihilus.

Each vessel had brought an arcane energy projector as large as a hive city, accompanied by cults of dark magi devoted to Vashtorr. Each had delivered its device to the *Orac Unleashed*, at that time still undergoing Vashtorr's modifications in readiness for the battle it would soon lead. At the direction of the Arkifane, the cults had laboured to attach the colossal projectors to the Ark. Each cannon, linked one to the next, formed part of the immense super-weapon that Vashtorr named the Unmaker.

Now, as the *Orac Unleashed* piled on speed from its hundreds of mismatched thrusters and closed

THE NAMELESS GATE

Azrael emerged atop the steep stair set into the south wall of the Gallerium Exactor. The battle spread out below him. The gallerium had long been a sombre and imposing space, its rocky alcoves lined with towering statues of Chapter heroes each as tall as a Warhound Titan. More statues stood in a row along the centre of the chamber, each atop a plinth large enough to land a flight of Stormravens on. Its vaulted roof spaces were fitted with panels of stained armaglass, subtly lit from behind. Most impressive of all was the colossal Nameless Gate set into the chamber's east wall. The gate's arch bore graven grotesques, cowled and robed in stone. Its doors were titanic slabs of obsidian and were symbolically chained shut with iron links each larger than a Dreadnought.

Where once this cavernous chamber had rung to the sombre chant of initiation rites, now it had become a battleground. Servitors had raised prefabricated barricades in overlapping semicircles radiating out from the Nameless Gate. Two of the chamber's ancient and irreplaceable statues had been felled with carefully placed melta charges. Their shattered corpses provided further cover for the defenders while blocking the most direct assault route from the foot of the Stair of Shadows.

A substantial force of Dark Angels from multiple companies manned the defences. Their ranks were supplemented by Firestrike Servo-turrets, Thunderfire Cannons and a phalanx of the Chapter's mightiest Dreadnoughts. It was a force with the martial might to conquer a city, end a xenos invasion or reclaim a lost world. Still it reeled beneath the infernal onslaught beating against it.

Azrael saw the main thrust of the attack was being made by a mass of nightmarish daemons. The unholy entities seemed little impeded by the Dark Angels' defences. Plague daemons trudged stolidly through raking fire, oozing like pus around or even through solid obstacles. Scintillating entities swooped high to rain mutagenic flame into the battle below as shimmer-skinned things of flesh, blades and silk danced in and out of reality, keening with agonised delight at every blow struck or received. All the while a spearhead of crimson-skinned warrior daemons drove inexorably into the Dark Angels' defences with unholy horns blaring, as infernal engines behind the lines lobbed bombardments of sizzling warp-energies in support.

Even as the defenders were pressed hard by this malefic onslaught, so Azrael saw that a band of Black Legionnaires had swept out around the loyalists' left flank and were poised to strike like a dagger to their ribs. Most monstrous of all was the daemonic lord who advanced steadily toward the Nameless Gate, eyes blazing like arc lumen through the pollutant smog billowing about him.

The Supreme Grand Master of the Dark Angels was determined that no foe should pass the Nameless Gate. In doing so they would delve deep into the Rock, prying into those secrets the Dark Angels revealed to none. Should the fighting spill beyond those doors he would be faced with the quandary of sending uninitiated battle-brothers to fight amidst revelations for which they were unprepared. The spiritual wounds inflicted by such an act might be worse even than the physical devastation wrought so far by the hated invaders. Azrael had issued orders to Ezekiel and Lazarus by vox that all committed to this fight should die with their backs to the Nameless Gate before they allowed such a disaster. Now, having appraised the dire situation, he led the advance down the steep stone steps to join the fight.

A flight of jump troops rocketed out from the stair-top on trails of flame, plunging into the daemonic host with guns blazing. The Black Legionnaires below turned too late as Azrael stormed toward them with his host of wrathful angels at his heels. The Dark Angels unleashed a storm of fire into the Heretic Astartes, felling some and wounding more. Cursing the lingering weakness that made his hearts pound arrhythmically and put a limp in his step, Azrael led the charge to lock blades with a sneering Black Legion Sorcerer at the foot of the stairs.

The Black Legionnaires had been outflanked, but they were far too veteran a band of warriors to panic. Instead, they dispersed smoothly and hammered their attackers with volleys of fire intended to bottle the loyalists up on the exposed stairway. Dark Angels staggered, or tumbled from the high steps to crash to the flagstones below. Yet the pale figures of the Deathwing came to the fore, weathering the traitors' fire and forging indomitably ahead.

As the warriors of the Inner Circle secured a foothold around their Supreme Grand Master, so more battle-brothers flooded down behind them and fanned out to engage the traitors in a point-blank firefight. Azrael himself vented his fury upon Sorcerer Lord Xorphas, whose expression of contempt curdled to alarm as he felt the psychic radiance of his enemy's fury. Azrael swung the Sword of Secrets in a thunderous arc, his opponent only just intercepting the blade with his own. The Sorcerer's eyes blazed with dark power and a bolt of purple lightning erupted from his free hand toward Azrael's chest. The energies

